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Jon Weber

Jon Weber is a musician who embraces challenges. His virtuoso piano can be heard in the role of soloist, sideman and vocal accompanist. He is a prolific composer/arranger and has recorded his original work, most notably on the 2004 release "Simple Complex." Jon recently welcomed a new challenge following Marian McPartland as the new host of NPR's Piano Jazz Rising Stars.

Jon was interviewed in Clinton, New York on June 2, 2012, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm welcoming Jon Weber to campus. Welcome, on our 200th Anniversary.

JW: Thank you, Monk.

MR: As you can tell there's a lot of stuff going on.

JW: It's a pleasure to be here. Actually I understand there's a parade, there's bagpipes, there's a ton of people, and it's the Bicentennial. How many colleges can say that in America?

MR: Really. But I've been practicing this little bit, because I can use this intro with you and no one else. Jon Weber, heavy metal guitarist, whose life was changed by a big band.

JW: Yes. You have done your reading. Yes that's exactly — I was a heavy metal guitarist. I was 16 playing with guys older than me in bars, playing heavy metal. God knows where I would have been had I pursued that path — I may be deaf or dead, or who knows what. But I happened to get a phone call from a guy named Mark Kleckley. This was in Milwaukee where I grew up. I was 16. And he said, "Our big band piano player just quit. We have a big band that rehearses every Sunday and we need somebody. I heard you're a pretty good jazz piano player." "Well I'm a guitar player now, I haven't touched a piano in two years."

MR: But you started on piano.

JW: I did, at three.

MR: Okay. And then you went to the guitar.

JW: Yes, I mean, again, every kid has this struggle of do I play baseball, do I play a musical instrument and get beaten up for playing tuba or accordion or whatever instrument. Even piano wasn't as cool as guitar. For some reason I thought I have to be a guitar player. Which, it helped. I sort of learned how to have some dexterity in my left hand. I paid attention to it more than I would have otherwise I suppose. But heavy metal guitar, that was where I was, and thank God Mark Kleckley, what a great name and what a great

out once." I did, and it changed my life. Because there were musicians who were all older than me. They were all college and up, and I was 16. And I walked in and I was a self-taught, you know, a piano player. And they threw the first chart in front of me, I remember it was Thad Jones "Don't Get Sassy." It had to be 15 pages. Chord symbols. It was a professional level chart. And I looked at it — what's C sharp plus nine thirteen — what is that? And I had perfect pitch so [scats]. I was through the Milli Vanilli piano for a while, I didn't know what to play. I was faking it. They were all so good. And oh gosh. It was a blues, so I could hear that much. And then a solo. Now what? So I faked it, and at the end of the day I almost slunk out of there I was so embarrassed. Two hours of this. And these people were so good and I was this kid — what do I have to chase? I wish I had taken those lessons. But the leader, Mark Kleckley, said, "Hey that was terrific. For a first shot out that was great." And I said, "Aww I disrupted your practice." And he said, "No come back next week. Here's a couple of books that might help you." Books with pictures of hands playing the chords — all 97 chords, every key, every inversion. That's what that's called? Oh that's what an F sharp flat thirteen sharp nine looks like and sounds like. I can do that. And I studied, came back the next week a little bit faster, you know still awful, but within six months just through sheer repetition I got a little bit faster and a little bit — I could have probably read the Tonight Show Band charts because I was doing nothing else.

MR: From what I read you sound like one of those people who would have driven a classical piano teacher crazy, because you would have heard the piece and been able to play a lot of it without reading it. Did you resist learning to read music?

JW: I didn't have to because I was learning to use my ear very quickly. We had seven kids in the family. I was the baby. So it was just a luxury we really couldn't afford. And we got my mother's mom's player piano. We inherited that from my grandma. She was 80 when I was born. And at grandma's house there would be the piano player with the rolls. Remember the rolls that look like the Scott towels you put it in with the holes and you pump up the stairmaster and played songs, air is forced through and the keys play it out. So mesmerized by this at grandma's house, grandma bequeathed her piano to my Mom. So that's in the house. So I've got that, with which I practiced all the time. And I'm trying to get back to the original question, a nice way of tying this together is that —

MR: The reading music.

JW: The reading wasn't — I never had to do it because I had gotten lazy with it because I would hear something on the radio and I would play it. Because again, when you're small enough you don't have the adult problems, you haven't yet stared the grim face of adulthood down head on, with its mortgage and car payments and alimony or whatever

— this is fun. So that was nearly a hundred percent of my waking day. So reading, kind of, I was blindsided by the reading situation when I was 16 and found a solution to it immediately thanks to Mark Kleckley.

MR: Was there a point where you said I want to be a musician? I want to make a living as a musician.

JW: I was three. I told my mother and she told me this, she said, "Jon you said, 'I'm going to be a piano player whether you like it or not.' 'I'm going to be a piano player the rest of my life whether you like it or not.'" Wow. Because I really wanted it. And in fact she saved, I had a little green 3 X 5 card where I scribbled in pencil, "Someday I will fly all over the globe and play piano." And she gave me a globe. And I'd spin the globe around and I'd say, "I'm going to play there and I'm going to play piano there and I'm going to" — "Well what if they don't speak any English in Mauritania" or wherever I was pointing at. "Well I'll just play piano. I don't have to talk. I'll just play." And guess what? When I go to these places that's exactly what happens. I remember the first gig I did overseas years and years ago, it was in Estonia, and I played something, and I remember the moment — it was a hilarious moment when, for no apparent reason I decided to quote [scats] "Yankee Doodle" — for no apparent reason, it just fit into the chord changes. And everybody laughed. It just happened. That was it. That's what I want. I want to communicate the close encounter that brings Spielberg back in.

MR: That's really cool. And I followed a little bit of that path, but I have a feeling that all that, plus with your heavy metal guitar really congealed for you. Because I have this weird thing with guitars. Like guitar players don't necessarily know what they're doing. That's my sense of it. That doesn't mean they're not good. I mean I've played with some guitar players who if you ask them the chord they'll show you, "Here's what it is" and show the hand. Yet their ears are so good I'm jealous.

JW: Oh I understand completely. Guitar is sort of what a piano is about a hundred years ago. A lot of people had access to one. I mean a hundred years ago almost every house, or a lot of houses, had a piano in the parlor, and everybody could read music on it. And today piano is just a large bulky instrument and it's easier for people to have a guitar and for some reason it seems that they can instantly play music on it in a way that sounds pretty much like what they hear on the radio. In other words, and I don't want to say that the bar has been lowered that far that you can now play music from the radio — but I guess I am saying that. I mean I can't help but say it. Because it is easier. You're playing fewer chords, you're not reading any notes to play A minor and E minor and G and C, you can pretty much get by with that much, and even less today with the synthesized notes, you just hit a button and it plays for you. But I understand. I understand how you feel about

very guitaristic, it sounds very familiar. Like, "Okay, that sounds like a great guitar player." And you can sound like a great guitar player I guess easier than you can sound like a great, great, great piano player.

MR: Okay.

JW: You follow that line of reasoning?

MR: Yeah, yeah.

JW: Especially if you've got a fuzz box and you've got distortion and all the gizmos and the volume at 100 decibels.

MR: So I'm not likely to see you in an ad for a music college saying, "You should come here because my career really started here." You were able to sort of bypass that whole jazz education at a college level thing or not?

JW: Yes. Well I ended up auditing a number of classes when I went to the University of Wisconsin Milwaukee, I went for four years and I had like eight different majors. Because I thought the voice of reason — my parents — entered into it. They said, "You know we like your music but you need something to think about, the Plan B."

MR: The fall-back-on.

JW: You know? And I said okay, accounting and mathematics, I'm no good at that, what else, oh jeez. You know, but there would be the piano over in the corner and I'd think okay I'll play for five minutes. Four hours later I was still playing. I managed to get decent enough grades and I thought I'm going to be a piano player the rest of my life, as I warned my mother at age three — "I'm going to be a piano player and this is what I'm going to pursue." But no the jazz academic route is something that I missed entirely. I ended up writing charts for other students. In other words I remember doing a 100-piece orchestration for a woman I had a big crush on. And sometimes I wrote big band charts for Mark Kleckley's band once in a while. And other combos. I had a quintet who opened up for people like Pat Metheny and Buddy Rich.

MR: So you just learned about voicing and ranges and all that from listening and talking to the players?

JW: Yes. Trial and error and I'd ask them, I'd say "what's the highest note you want to hit on a tenor saxophone?" "Well you get to this point and then you hit an altissimo." "All right, what's the best range for a trombone? What's the toughest position?" "Seventh. Stay away from it." And then Henry Mancini of all people — I was playing a gig in a hotel, quite young, and he walks in. What do you give him? I have a game with my best friend, John Ramirez back in Chicago, we call "what do you give 'em?" Which means if somebody famous comes in, what do you have ready for them that's going to blow them away. We also have a game called "what don't you give?" For example, if Francis Ford

example, if Paul McCartney were to walk in what do you give him? Well I'm not going to give him a Beatle song, I'm not going to even give him a post-Beatle song. I'm going to lay this one on him. Do I have time to give this 30-second anecdote?

MR: Yeah.

JW: Are you familiar with the composer Jack Lawrence?

MR: No.

JW: Jack Lawrence wrote a string of pop hits in the forties, fifties, sixties, anyway, one of which he wrote for his friends John and Louise Eastman and their daughter Linda, who was about kindergarten age. This was 1946. He wrote a song for the kid. Oh, how does it go? Her name is Linda. "When I go to sleep/I never count sheep/I count all the charms about Linda. Lately it seems/in all my dreams/I dream with my arms about Linda. You've heard that song perhaps?

MR: Um hum.

JW: A whole bunch of Lindas. They listen to the song, oh that's nice, and you can hear a cash register ringing. Lo and behold they did release it and it became a — Buddy Clark sang it, an enormous hit and it was on the hit parade at least two months, it was top of the charts a bunch of that time. Tons of girls named Linda after that. All right fast forward. The girl for whom that song was written, Linda, March 12, 1969 guess what she does?

MR: She marries Paul McCartney.

JW: Exactly. So, he owns that song. He bought the rights to that song. Now if Paul McCartney wanders in, what do you give him? You give him "Linda." So in any case, Henry Mancini walks in what do you give him? It's hard to lay in all these tunes on him from his film scores that he thought, "Who knows this?" He even at one point, he's got his arms crossed and he's kind of half-smiling at me, what a great guy he was. April 16, 1924, I observe his birthday. In any case, and June 14, 1984, his death. But he said, "Come here a second, how old are you?" I said, "25." He said, "How do you know so many of my songs?" I said, "Well you're a famous guy. Of course I know these songs." "And what was that second to the last one?" "Oh that was 'Blue Sad' and you did that with Jay Livingston and Ray Evans, guys who were born six weeks apart in 1950." And he loved it. He loved it, and we started laughing about some of it, and he said, "Oh yeah, that was in the 'Mr. Lucky' TV show, you remember?" And he said "yeah, I do. We wrote those in five minutes sometimes." Anyway, how we got on Henry Mancini, I'm trying to remember how we —

MR: Well I'm not sure, you were talking about what do you give them?

JW: Yeah, what do you give them. So Hank Mancini, he came back the next two nights, three nights in a row, and he gave me a book, this is the reason I brought it up. He gave me a

which they're comfortable, all the things I'd ever want to know about orchestration were in that book. So that helped a ton. I learned a little bit, it sort of backed up everything that I'd learned on my own, but there it was in black and white, and that's my Bible. I refer to that often.

MR: You know there's nothing like that feeling, pre-Finale or Sibelius, of writing a piece, and you know you check it at the piano, but you're never really sure it's going to work until all those human beings get there and they read it.

JW: You're right, and there are people who write vertically and there are people who write horizontally. I mean Mancini for example writes vertically, meaning you could take any cross section of any conductor's score and it's going to be a fabulous chord. He thinks that way, he thinks vertically. And Duke Ellington for example, thought horizontally. Everybody's line had to be something really hip. And it somehow works horizontally. And I don't know if anybody ever analyzed it that way. Maybe this is the advantage of not studying music, it's just that's the way it sounds to me.

MR: I think that's a great point. Because I remember listening to him some recently and I was trying to figure out what is it that make him sound like he does. And that's a very good sort of observation. And what you just said too. What did you just say?

JW: Vertically or horizontally.

MR: Yeah but then after that you said not knowing music theory or — that there's some advantage to that.

JW: Yeah. In other words, by ear I manage to pick out what each individual line was in the Duke score from 1927 and I said oh every single line works somehow. You know vertically it may not work quite as well, but horizontally everybody's got something cool to play. So it keeps them happy in that way. And Mancini and a number of other composers have the technique of writing vertically, which means it's pleasing for the conductor and perhaps for a larger audience. I don't know. I should analyze it further.

MR: I wonder if that has to do anything with, you know Duke knew who he was writing for.

JW: Yes. And similarly, Henry Mancini even says in his book, he says, "If you have the luxury of knowing who your players are, there's no greater advantage to an arranger and conductor than that. Because if you have a swell tuba player who can really get around the tuba, write in some tuba parts. Write some cool stuff for them to do. So I guess both answers are right.

MR: Present day, if you look at your — I'm leapfrogging here — but if you're doing your taxes at the end of the year and you're looking at how you make a living, is it mostly from playing gigs and touring? Does selling CDs come into it? Does writing charts? And how is it divided up for you.

JW: Since I moved to New York I write a lot more charts because I finally broke down and got the music transcription software — I use Finale. I should learn Sibelius it's similar. I should know them both. But I would say when I was living in Chicago, until 2006, I was playing, I would say that 99.9 percent of my income came from playing gigs and touring. And now, in New York, where there's 80 million crazy ways to make money as a musician, I'll play for a vocalist, I'll write out charts for someone, I'll write out arrangements for someone, I'll do a radio show. You never know. So now, when I do my tax return, as you say, I look at it and I kind of smile thinking oh when did I find time to do all this stuff. This is great. And your resume builds. And I'm happy about that because I end up learning — playing for singers is something that a lot of instrumentalists, particularly piano players, think oh jeez do I have to do this. But I enjoy it, because I always learn new tunes. For example if I'm doing a gig with a vocalist who's doing 22 numbers, sometimes I have to learn 14 of them. Good. About time. Sometimes you need to get your butt kicked to learn new music and there's no more dramatic way of being compelled to learn new music is the gig Saturday you've got to have charts ready to go for the band.

MR: Who's the more challenging vocalist to work with usually, the fabulous vocalist or the vocalist who maybe shouldn't be doing this gig.

JW: Keep your daughter off the stage Mrs. Worthington? The latter. Because you always want to work with people who are better than you, people who can do something that you can't do. Because then you're learning. Because otherwise if you're just picking somebody up, you're spending all your time babysitting and you're not learning.

MR: Yeah. You probably get a sense fairly quickly in working with a particular singer like I need to lead this person a little bit or not be too — my substitutions, watch out for them. Right.

JW: Um hum. Well I look to people like Nelson Riddle, Axle Stordahl and even people with film scores like Erich Korngold, you just listen to what's going on behind the action. And you know how much you can get away with almost immediately if you're doing stuff and they get lost. But that rarely happens. I mean usually they can follow. Because they're used to playing with something — in other words I will stray from the standard changes after a chorus or two. And the vocalists welcome that. They actually are happy that I'm doing that instead of just playing some basic cotton candy arrangement that's written bare bones for somebody to play with their hands about this far apart. And they're about this far apart and it actually sounds a little bit more orchestral for some reason. More jazzy. And people, I find that vocalists do enjoy that, and I never play the melody. I remember learning that a long time ago. I played for a vocal jazz group in college. A professor

audited the class. I did it because I just wanted to meet girls. But I was playing with them and I learned, again, less is more, don't try to overplay them, don't try to upstage them. Just do your thing. If they look good you look good. And again, a lot of times I'll actually take my hands completely off the keys and I'll allow some silence. Because if there's a vocal person, that's a brave thing to do. I know that as a heavy metal singer too. Getting up and singing in front of a crowd is a brave thing to do. You know if a vocalist is doing it and somebody is yapping away in the audience, one way to make them knock it off is to have these moments of silence where you can hear a pin drop. And they'll stop talking. It happens. It's a powerful thing and it makes everybody feel better because they think how cool are we as an audience to have just done that. And it's like crack, you immediately are seduced into craving more, I want that, I want that silent moment again. So yeah, silence is golden when you're accompanying a vocalist.

MR: Good point. Do you like working more in a just piano/vocal or with a bass player or it doesn't even matter?

JW: If I'm playing with the vocalist for the very first time, piano is safer. The more musicians you add the more chances you take and the bigger gamble it is that you're going to get something that's going to clash with somebody else. I welcome the challenge but if I'm by myself the chances of everything going right are just greater just by sheer laughing statistical chance. But it's fun. Nothing is more fun than a jam session at a club like Mona's. There's place in Alphabet City in New York that happens to be on 13th Street where a bunch of college kids, twenty-somethings are dressing up in suits and Stetsons and they're playing like Louis Armstrong, like Lester Young, and they're respecting the whole tradition. It's a blast to be around them. I forget why I went that way, but we were talking about something a moment ago, it's just that somebody waved at me from the window so I was thrown off.

MR: Well we were talking about working with other people.

JW: We did, and those folks work together so often and they kind of, the magical thing that happens sometimes if somebody is singing for example, somebody is singing like Billie Holiday or singing like Bessie Smith. It's an amazing club, you'll have to go there sometime. The horn players [scats] and everybody [scats] all of a sudden six horn players are doing that rhythm with something that fits.

MR: Cool.

JW: And it sounds almost like an arrangement. And sometimes it even happens vocally. I remember we did "'Deed I Do" where somewhere we broke into four part harmony. I thought I'm going to take the one that's really, really high so that nobody will step on my feet, and sure enough, it just happened. Sometimes that kind of magical thing will happen

MR: I'm glad to hear that that happens, because that's the hardest thing to teach in jazz school I think, that human interaction, learning the tradition, doing it on-the-spot in front of an audience.

JW: Yeah, there's a lot of spontaneity. I think, you know it's probably today — as of the time of this recording, which is 2012 if I'm allowed to mention that —

MR: Oh yeah.

JW: I don't know if you want to mark some things in time. But anyway, no, today there are more places to get a jazz education than maybe ever before. But again, there's no substitute for just getting on the stand and making the stumbles and falls and the wrong turns that you have to make in order to learn how to blend.

MR: Well you're a guy who seems — from what I've read and some YouTube things — you seem pretty comfortable on stage.

JW: I like it on stage. It's a very fun place to be. And if I could look people in the eye on stage it's a blast. If it's a big gigantic thing — and I've played some huge ones in my day — there's something about playing in a room where there's a few hundred people. Because you can look at everybody and anybody in the audience can get the feeling that if I hadn't been here it might have been a different kind of a show. In this way: how many times have you been in an audience where you initiated the clapping or you laughed at something and it changed the momentum of the entire performance, where the front person or whoever was playing was encouraged, and something happened. Some spark. And I like those moments, and I like audiences that are small enough where any individual can be that person to trigger something special. I've been on both sides. I've been on stage when it's happened and I've been in the audience.

MR: Did the heavy metal band help you become comfortable on stage?

JW: Maybe. I will tell you this. I was 14, 15, 16 when I was playing heavy metal, and I played in bars, where there was grown-ups, and grown-up stuff was going on. And I learned that I never wanted to consume alcohol at all. I think I became allergic to it just by watching. I thought I don't want to act like that. You know it's fine for people who want to do it, that's fine, they look like they're having a great time. But I don't want to look like that. And I remember the only time I've ever had a drink on stage I was playing a place called The Estate. I had to be 17 years old, in Milwaukee, a little club. It was hot, and I was playing, it was probably two in the morning and I was doing the thing with all the guys and a couple of women at that point. The women were starting to play more jazz even then. And someone said, "What are you drinking?" I said, "Ginger ale." Somebody brought me a ginger ale and I just drank it and it was terrible. They said, "You want another?" I said, "Sure" you know. So I had two whiskey sours in about 45 seconds. I

dilated and at sixteenths and eighths became triplets and what happened? I didn't like it. I don't like the experience of being out of control on stage or off. So yes, the heavy metal experience taught me oh, this is what I don't want to do the rest of my life.

MR: Good experience.

JW: Yeah. I was glad. If I hadn't encountered that who knows, maybe I would have followed a different route. I've still never smoked marijuana my entire life, what kind of a musician am I? And I don't drink. Although you will probably observe younger musicians — I'm 51 — people younger than me are, the next generation of musicians are the healthiest bunch of people. You know? I mean in Duke's day at three in the morning, "Let's go get a steak and a bottle of champagne and some heroin" or whatever. I'm kidding. But I mean it was some very unhealthy things. And today it's, "I'll have the vinaigrette black bean soup and the Caesar and the bottle of water. Healthy. Can you believe this? And that's good. I guess maybe that means that musicians have more self-respect. I don't know what it is. And maybe the chances of them doing okay are better than they used to be. I mean if you were a jazz musician of a few generations ago it might have been, "Oh a jazz musician, harrumph." Now it's okay. Especially, I mean in Europe. My gosh, if you go over there it's as normal an occupation as working in a bank or selling insurance. "What do you do?" "I'm a musician." Oh, okay. Over here, "Musician" hum. There's still a little bit of a stigma but it's better than it was.

MR: I think sometimes the audience in the older days liked the fact that those musicians were going to die young. It's like let them be that way so we can watch. You know, or then we can tell stories about like Bix Beiderbecke, of course, he'll live on forever partly because he died so young. And the tragic hero I suppose.

JW: There is the mystique of the dark side, the flirtation with the vice that jazz brings — all the best jazz photography is black and white, smoky club basements, sweaty and guys going "yeah, yeah." You know there's this whole feeling of sort of nocturnal and nefarious and sort of, oh — and even here I'm the most substance-free musician there is, but I like going out to a place at three in the morning because there's something about that life, something about that energy that really attracts me and attracts a lot of people, musicians and non-musicians alike.

MR: Well, let's talk about NPR. I have a feeling that there are probably quite a number of piano players who were jealous of your picking up Marian's [McPartland] mantle. That's my guess.

JW: I am humbled beyond belief that Marian has chosen me to follow her concept into the next generation. I'm very, very happy about it. She started something in 1978 from scratch. There were no jazz radio programs like it. There wasn't one where you brought

time at the Hickory House" "remember at the Palladium when the Duke was there, yeah, and Tito Puente walked in and Monk was there." They have these stories, these jazz stories, that sort of humanize jazz musicians and in a little bit take away from the mystique and make them, oh jazz musicians aren't so brooding and indecipherable as I had thought, they're just regular people. And yes, to take on, to follow Marian's concept is an honor that I am humbled beyond belief. I try to research everything about every guest that I have on the show. I try to download and study every single piece of music they've ever released. I look for bootlegs. I look for everything as far as YouTube, and everywhere. Everywhere I can find something about them back to junior high. Newspaper clippings. Because I want to know something, I want to ask something if I possibly can that hasn't been asked before. Marian does this naturally. Marian could just listen to someone's records, in those days the albums and probably iron clothes and make a turkey and, you know, write a chart. And then the next day go on the show and say, "Oh yes on the eighth album on the second side that thing you did in your solo, I got a kick out of it." She remembers everything. She remembers everything. She's so smart and so wonderful and so giving that I hope the Kennedy Center honors her soon for her contribution. How can you give seven decades plus in the manner and style that she has without honoring that? I keep on saying that I'm humbled by this. And yeah I keep scratching my head saying boy am I lucky. Why me? I'm delighted to do this as long as I can, as long as there are people interested in the concept of bringing in the musician and doing not seven needle drops, but seven live performances in the studio. And that's an extraordinary thing. She, again, created out of nothing, they said, "If you were a kid in a candy store, what would you do?" I don't know I'd have my friends on and we'd play and talk. How fortunate is that?

MR: She's a great lady and I had the experience of when I taught high school having her come. I mean she was doing high school assemblies. This was 1975. And someone booked her in the school I was teaching at. And I don't think they even knew who she was. And I said Marian McPartland is coming to our school? And I got some money together and had her come back and play with my junior high kids you know. I was like oh my God she was just so giving like you said.

JW: She is. I don't think she ever forgot what it was like to be a kid and to have the wonder and the feeling about improvisation. Because I think kids naturally want to be creative. And to steer them that way, the way Marian does when she does her clinics over the years. I definitely — everyone wants to be like her.

MR: So how do you choose your guests? Do you choose them?

JW: It's half and half. Some of them, when I filled in for Marian for about three years they

sometimes they'll say, "Who do you want to bring on?" I've got lucky once in a while and got to choose. On "Piano Jazz Rising Stars" there are some, just people who are obvious candidates. Kris Bowers for example just won the Thelonious Monk piano competition. Aaron Diehl, a tremendous young stride piano player, a bebop piano player/arranger, started out as a classical player until college, as was Stefon Harris, who played about twenty instruments. I think every high school bandleader's dream. The kid who could play every instrument. Because he'd just take ahold of a trombone and start playing "The Pink Panther" with the TV. But so Stefon Harris, Jason Moran, named the Kennedy Center adviser, and Hiromi. Hiromi was a blast. She was fortunate enough in Japan to have a music teacher who told her, "Play your Hanon exercises but swing them." "How do I swing them?" "Like this." This is in Japan. Now you would think in Japan you would imaging a very, very strict play the notes, play the ink. "Why don't you swing it?" Can you imagine that? So some people I absolutely had to have on the show. Sachal Vasandani was a great guitarist. I had Taylor Eigsti, Julian Lage, Grace Kelly, I've been really, really fortunate.

MR: And how much time do you get to do the show with these people? I mean in the actual taping of it?

JW: If you get lucky you can do it — well we have to stop and start because it's no longer a situation where you have two pianos next to each other anymore and you could just sit at the piano. Now it's done where the interviewing is done in the booth and then we say "well what about this tune?" "Oh yeah, I'd love to play it." And you play it and you stop. And so, a couple of hours and you can get everything done.

MR: Yeah.

JW: And sometimes it goes faster than other times, but everybody — I've never had anything other than a great guest. They've all been special and extraordinary and I've learned something from every single one of them.

MR: Do you do any private teaching?

JW: See I never took any piano lessons so I don't think I have the right to rap anybody's knuckles. But yes, I mean — what, tell me?

MR: Well, you have something, I'm sure, that a lot of piano teachers don't have — practical experience in how to play what your ear is telling you and all that kind of stuff. And that's valuable.

JW: If anything — and I have had a number of students over the years, some stride students who want to learn how to do that because it's just something that's so old that very few people do it anymore. Although there's a wave of young players coming up right now who are fascinating for that very reason. It's something that's so old that they're listening

as well. And sometimes the sheet music doesn't capture what the live recording does, the groove, the bounce. So if I have students, and every once in a while I'll do some clinics overseas and in colleges. And I love it. Because people are surprised at how much they know already. In other words, I remember in Australia talking to some kids and I brought them all on stage. I got there an hour and a half before the show and I said, "How many chairs can we fit on stage?" We brought all the chairs up on stage so they could actually — I took the top off the piano so they could see all the internal mechanisms, and they liked that. And I played something for them and it was a Christmas carol that had some Australian words so it's sort of the Jingle bells/Batman smells/Robin laid an egg sort of thing. But in Australia "Doggie in the boot" and "tuscayute" and all these Australian slang things. And they loved that. And I said, "How many times have you listened to your — it's not a walkman it's an iPad, and you heard a note or a word that you changed to your own. And you changed something — it wasn't Lady Gaga's, it wasn't 50 Cent or somebody's. And oh they unanimously agreed, yes I've changed some of these. Well you're improvising. I said, "The fancy word to describe that is 'improvising.'" They were making something up that wasn't there before. "You are doing a variation on something that was already there." And I said, "If you can do that, it's a very small step to improvising everything."

MR: I was listening to you play "Green Dolphin Street" and I heard you play "Frankie and Johnny."

JW: Really?

MR: Yeah really. I knew you were going to say that, or I thought you would. "Really?" Like it almost was so subtly done, but I'm pretty sure it was, but I remember at the moment listening to it. I wonder if you knew that you did that or if it was just so — it was a half a quote almost.

JW: I think I remember the venue. I think it was The Artist's Corner in Minneapolis and you probably saw it on YouTube maybe? Alex Hahn on alto sax?

MR: Yeah.

JW: An alto sax player kid, he's about 24. Unbelievable. I did a gig with him when he was 17. In any case yeah, the spare parts. Teddy Wilson, the great pianist whose centennial is this year on the 24th of November, 1912, he used to call them "spare parts." Where you'd be playing a song and all of a sudden you'd hear [scats] and it's sneaking in there. It's a joke. It's a little jest. It's a little sneaky thing that, it fits. Some people force/impose them and go out of their way to put in something silly.

MR: Especially at Christmastime.

JW: Especially at Christmastime, right. Oh this is a good 35 Christmas carols. If I hear

will try to answer that person by doing a quote from the bridge. That's my drill. But the spare parts. I love it. That's, to me, when somebody does that, when someone takes a snip of another song and puts it in on the fly in real time into the song, and then goes back to what they were doing — oh where was I — that's a pretty high level of human expression if you think about it. They were already improvising over chords, a new melody in real time, not the slow motion composition. You know Wayne Shorter said something about composition is improvising in slow motion and improvising is composition in fast motion or real time, which I love. But they're on the fly improvising something and then taking a snip of another song — oh I think I'll take this one out of orbit for a second and put it in, and, no, put it back.

MR: Right. Because you have to know what pitch that quote starts on too, right. You can't just like — unless you're doing it out of key on purpose or something.

JW: Well that used to happen a lot. I remember I had a gig with a gentleman named John Faushager and we used to quote things like "Daniel Boone" — something that didn't have any business being in there, and we'd make it off key to see if we could even turn their head after a while, "Don't you hear that?" We'll make is a flat nine and see.

MR: Do you have a manager or anything like that or do you just handle your own —

JW: My manager is the cell phone in my pocket which I hope I turned off. But yeah, people call and I have enough work to keep me happy. I guess that's a good place to be, where you have enough steady work to continually to do something seven days a week if you want to, but not so much work that your life is dictated by your fame. I'm not famous. I'm in a type of music that is not popular music. So that's fine with me.

MR: I have a student who is a very good piano player in high school. And I struggle with advising him. He wants to go into music. Now I don't think he has the innate ability to be the next Bill Evans or that kind of thing. But I think he could make a living in the music business. And I guess I'm not sure what to tell him. Do you have advice for young musicians, how to get ahead?

JW: What's motivating him to play right now? I mean if someone has, I mean some musicians come from a place where they have stage mothers or fathers who will go on to be the next American Idol. And other kids, they can't even help it, they just love to play so much that they're naturally inclined to do it and they're brave enough to pursue it and to have the attention span to do it for hours and hours a day. So I'm assuming he's a young gentleman. If he has the interest in doing it all the time and is willing to give up everything — I hear this sometimes from wealthy folks who will come along and say, "you know I was a lawyer, a doctor all my life, and I'd give anything to do what you do." Guess what? You do have to give up everything. Look at me. I mean I'm not — this is

going to be necessarily — who knows, maybe he will be the next big thing, maybe he'll stumble on some thing and really get into it. It sounds like he's into it already.

MR: Yeah. He is, that's his situation. He loves to play. It's sort of ironic now that to pursue that likely you have to give up everything. First, most people have to go pay fifty grand to go to Berklee every year. You know, the investment, to put into it to get to that place where you're not going to be rich is a dichotomy of some —

JW: Although there is that one lucky person who breaks through and you never know who it's going to be. Sometimes the nerdy kid with the horned-rimmed glasses ends up — I'm not saying that's your student — but I'm saying the least likely to succeed — I don't even remember this kid in high school — ten thousand bucks a gig? Jeez, what happened? It could happen you know. You never know what the next big thing is going to be and you never know if they come up — who knows? Thelonious Monk I'm certain was not thought to be the next Art Tatum in his day. They probably thought he doesn't sound like him, but he carved out his own thing. And it was extraordinary in its own way. You never know what you're going to get and that's the beauty of jazz anyway. You never know what you're going to get from moment to moment or over the course of your lifetime.

MR: Is there such a thing as a wrong note?

JW: No. No.

MR: Are you sure about that?

JW: No. No. No. Well if you're playing — okay — if you're playing Beethoven's ninth symphony yes. There's a wrong note there. If you're jazz — there was a great TED feature that Stefon Harris did called "There Are No Wrong Notes on the Bandstand" meaning in a jazz combo setting they were playing kind of an F suspension thing together with a little quartet. Stefon was playing vibes and there was a pianist and a drummer and a bass player, and he asked the pianist, he said, "F sharp" which is about as harsh as it gets okay, to most Western ears, out of the twelve possible notes of the scale, that's the hardest. He played that and everybody kept on playing in F and he said, "Now, to most people that sounds wrong. However, let's do this — they did the same thing, they vamped this thing in F and he played the F sharp. But he followed along in the F sharp thing this time. He said, "Now, the only reason this sounded wrong in the first place is because we didn't follow it." But when you follow it, and Frank Zappa says exactly the same thing. Whenever they made a goof on stage, and they always had these very intricate arrangements. If somebody had a goof, the goof became the new thing. They said, "Oh we love it, we love it." They followed the mistake. The mistake became the thing, until another mistake came along. They lived for mistakes. There'd be no laughter in a perfect world. So are there any wrong notes on the bandstand? You know something?

of a situation I don't think so. And in most situations I would say no. I would say a wrong note is a rarity. I'll compromise that much.

MR: All right. I like the description. You know there's a lot of different thoughts on it. You can go on the Internet and get all kinds of people talking about it. And some people have said you have to keep working on that note.

JW: What do you think? I mean are there any wrong notes?

MR: Well I'm more of a — I'm changing my mind some. I used to think yeah, there's definitely wrong notes that you can play. And I've heard people play them. But then I started to think about — usually — you know if Stefon Harris plays an F sharp in that thing, it's different than when a junior high kid plays an F sharp. Because Stefon will do it with attack, with purpose. A junior high kid maybe just is hitting a note and he doesn't know what exactly to do with it and so then it becomes, it sort of sits there feeling wrong.

JW: I guess I was thinking about being in a gig situation somewhere.

MR: Well that was my question.

JW: But when you're learning oh my gosh yes. And then transcriptions. I mean when I was coming up I would transcribe solos note for note and learn them. Yeah. At that stage yeah, I would say stick to the ink at that stage, early enough. And then learn what it's supposed to sound like. I guess again, what it's supposed to sound like. I don't know, maybe the wrong note thing is going to be the next big thing. I don't know. That's a possibility.

MR: What's up in the near future for you?

JW: The immediate future? I'm going to take a 2 a.m. bus back to New York City and go out to Scarsdale to play a gig, and then let's see I'm going to Azerbaijan in about a week.

MR: Wow.

JW: I've never been. I just want to see it. I want to see the Caspian Sea. I want to hang out. I don't know a soul there. I just want to take a look to see what I can hear, see what —

MR: Well you seem innately curious, and I also was thinking a couple of times I said I should get you and Phil Schaap together and you can have a —

JW: He's the Jeopardy champion. He would mop the floor with me. He knows everything.

MR: He does. But you seem to have a pretty encyclopedic knowledge, that you need anyway.

JW: I know some stray bizarre facts that create the illusion that I'm smart when I'm actually not. But no, I love the trivia and I love the birthdays and the numbers.

MR: Well I have to have my open house here so I'm going to wrap up and maybe down the line we'll do part two.

JW: Monk you are way too kind to me and I'm grateful. How cool is your name. I mean, for who were you named?

MR: Actually it was a nickname I picked up in college, and most people thought it was about Thelonious, but actually it was about a blue coat with a hood. And it stuck with me and eventually I became the name.

JW: You were wearing hoodies before they were cool, huh? Awesome.

MR: Well thanks for your time today and I hope your gig here at Hamilton goes well and that you make your 2 a.m. bus. We'll make sure that you're there.

JW: Monk, thanks a lot.

MR: Okay. Over and out.